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Dick Spottswood

Dick Spottswood possesses a wealth of knowledge about American music from the early twentieth century. He is a respected musicologist, record producer, radio host, and author.

Dick was interviewed via Zoom on February 13, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive, and I'm very happy to have Dick Spottswood with me this morning. Thanks for joining me.

DS: Glad to be with you.

MR: I'm going to sum up your career and then you can say if I left anything out. Musicologist, librarian, collector, discographer, radio host, author, and I assume fan of folk and ethnic music.

DS: From time to time all of those. Never everything at once.

MR: Yes. I wonder if when you were let's say before your teen years, is this what you envisioned your career as?

DS: No. I don't know. I never gave a thought to a career so much as what comes next. When I finished undergraduate school in 1960 I said I need to go find a trade or something. And at the time I was putting myself through school in large part by library work so I thought where do I sign up to do more of this, and it turned out that the University of Maryland was only a few miles up the road from Catholic University so I graduated from one and enrolled in the other. That was my career.

MR: It's funny how things turn out like that. I'm going to — this is a tough question perhaps — can you remember the first recorded music that you heard that sort of struck a nerve with you, that made your ears perk up?

DS: I can't remember not liking music at all or not responding to it. I guess sort of an answer to your question is what are my earliest music memories and there's one that really sticks out. I was born in 1937 so I would have been four I think when I heard the Ink Spots I guess it was, singing "I Don't Want to Set the World on Fire." I didn't respond to the Ink Spots so much as to the idea of arson, and the whole planet going up and at age four when people say things like that you hear them literally. So I remember asking my mom, "Why does that man want to blow up the world?" or words to that effect. And then I remember that recording again many, many, many years later when I was listening to Ma Rainey singing "Don't Fish in my Sea" and if you'll recall the Jimmy Blythe opener to that song where he goes [scats]. I'm thinking I've heard that somewhere before. And sure enough I went back like, this is only recently too, so I went back and dialed up the Ink

Spots' record and there was Jimmy Blythe's little opener. So they ripped that off from him, right? Or at least it was around in community folklore section, it was available to the Ink Spots fifteen years after Ma Rainey and Jimmy Blythe picked it up. I thought that was nice. And so I was listening to music carefully when I was only four years old.

MR: That's terrific. I like that community folklore like for licks. That's a community lick.

DS: Yeah, yeah, precisely. That's a much better word.

MR: Well I'm currently reading a couple of books and one is by Francis Davis, it's about the blues and I'm reading things that — this happens fairly often — where you think that you know some facts about music that are true. For instance Mamie Smith, first "Crazy Blues," that's okay the first blues recording. And then you read someone who writes —

DS: Well even that's arguable, isn't it?

MR: It is. That's what I'm saying. And it's hard to say things about music that are absolutely true.

DS: I can't think of the lady's name, the one who recorded the "Dallas Blues" in 1916 with the pianist that people thought was Lucky Roberts for years and years. Marie Cahill. My memory is going but I just remembered her name. Have you ever heard that recording?

MR: No but that's what I read yesterday. And that's what prompted this sort of like uh — I thought I knew this was true and you know this particular author, he pointed that out, that record.

DS: Well she was a white lady but she was singing with a deep south accent that I do not think was contrived and the record was like a 12 inch record so there was a little opening monologue but she sang a full-length version of "Dallas Blues" and it's not a bad performance.

MR: Does it frustrate you, or I'll just say make you crazy sometimes, that you can't say things with absolute certainty about music, how it developed, and this was the first, etcetera.

DS: I'm not sure — I'm not trying to sound like a smart ass here or anything but I'm not sure you can say much of anything with absolution about music history or you know, art history and the greater universe anyway. Usually whenever you find something that's a precedent as often as not there turns out to be a precedent to the precedent. And you know things seem to evolve as much as they are actually invented. And when they evolve they are really being re-invented because you'll hear some old music with a new suit of clothes or something to that effect.

MR: Well said. You know it gives professors something to always write about because you know they can't say anything with certainty so there's always different ways of looking at this Americana.

DS: That's right. And thankfully we have so many institutions willing to support that kind of speculation and research. Because you know the more we know about our history the greater the dimensionality that it has, not demented but dimension.

MR: Yes.

DS: And I welcome all of that.

MR: By the way this is an aside but yesterday I was poking around and I saw your book "Songs of Local History and Events" I think it's on the American Folk Music Library. And on Amazon they're selling copies for $199.

DS: This is that long-play record you're talking about?

MR: I'm talking about — yes that's right.

DS: Okay, okay now I know what you mean. They are? Well good luck to the purchaser.

MR: Do you have one?

DS: If he wants to share it with me then that's okay. I'll tell you what, I'll sell him another copy for the same price.

MR: I think the economic truism that supply and demand certainly applies to rare recordings and so forth. Do you have a memory of searching through bins and Salvation Army stuff, what has been some of the significant finds that you may recall?

DS: I've been very fortunate in that respect over the years and have found many good records like that too. You know because like it occurred to me when I was young that I was only going to find the music I liked or the records I liked by going through used record bins because they weren't for sale at retailers any longer. I was about twenty years too late for the music that really captured my imagination. So I still remember the first important record I ever found I was about eleven or twelve years old and I was with some relatives at some kind of a sale in a barn up in Central Pennsylvania and there were some old records and I thought well why don't I look through these. I was a little kid with nothing else to do. And I pulled up a copy of the "Kansas City Man Blues" by Clarence Williams' Blue Five. I had no idea who they were but it said blues on the other side too so I paid the dime or the quarter or whatever was required and got that record home and it turned out to be a monster. But I didn't even know how to pronounce Sidney Bechet's last name at that point. I just knew the music was good.

MR: That's a great story. Yeah, like oh who's this, is this Sidney Bechet and what does he play?

DS: Well his name wasn't on the record. I didn't learn that until later.

MR: How many years later was it that you discovered that this was a valuable purchase?

DS: Oh it didn't take long. I don't remember how that evolved. But as my interest in that music grew and I was able to articulate it a little better, you know I ran into other local people that played music and collected music. And you know I grew up in suburban

Washington, D.C. and that was a very cosmopolitan place. And no matter what your interests were if you poked around a little bit you could always find colleagues and enemies and other people that had to do with what you were interested in too.

MR: Did you become more attracted to instrumental music rather than vocalists or vocal groups?

DS: Nope. I like it both ways.

MR: I think they call that your tastes were catholic perhaps.

DS: Yep, that's right.

MR: What about the concept of musical forms. When do they become considered art?

DS: Oh I don't know that process is always evolving I think. You know I mean if you say art you're also saying what happens to be considered art at the moment you know. I remember Marshall McCluhan's classic definition of art being anything you could get away with. I think that applies to music too. You know? That's why I enjoy Sun Ra and Albert Ayler you know, not as much as I did King Oliver but you know, in its own way all that music was pretty wonderful.

MR: I'm letting that sink in for a moment. Because I'm somewhat familiar with those two gentlemen.

DS: Well I was hoping to use names that would mean something to you. I wasn't going to resort to my hillbilly music universe because I don't know how far you go in that direction. But the same thing holds true there. I grew up in Washington which was a — it wasn't in the north, it wasn't in the south, but it was where those two influences tended to evolve and so you could hear everything from — the richest on the radio from a cappella black Gospel to rhythm & blues to honky tonk country to early bluegrass. And you'd have to go out of your way to hear it but on Sunday nights there was a program coming out of — I think it was WWL in New Orleans that featured Johnny Wiggs and King Oliver type traditional jazz so I found out something about all that. All that was grist for my particular mill. I liked classical music. I loved Claudio Monteverdi's operas and masses and I liked Bela Bartok string quartets. All of that music is wonderful. I collected some of it but only because I couldn't collect all of it.

MR: I'm picturing you in your physical moves over the years. I remember in college we would have our boxes of LPs and then I have accepted a few collections of 78s here. And when I went to move them I was reminded of how fast technology moves with recording mediums.

DS: Each of those 78 RPM records weighs half a pound. So people that have to move them fairly often probably wind up getting back surgery.

MR: Years ago —

DS: I had to move mine again three years ago and I was glad I didn't have so many.

MR: Some years ago I went to the Belfer Audio Archive at Syracuse University, which is just down the road. And they were showing me the different devices, the Edison Diamond Disks and the cylinders and 78 players. And almost casually they said something about the controversy of cleaning up recordings like that so that they don't sound like they used to. So they're able to take out the hiss and the scratch and the almost built-in sound of the technology at the time. And that some people came down on the side of leave it alone, that was the listening experience. And some people said well listen, we have this technology to make it more palatable to listen to. Do you have any thoughts on that?

DS: Well as it happens you landed me right in the middle of the project that's been occupying a large number of my waking hours over the past couple of months so here it is, it's time for the commercial. I'm working on a project for GHB Records out of New Orleans, that's Lars Edegran, I'm sure you all know each other, that is going to consist of all of the surviving Ma Rainey records that anyone could find, and that includes outtakes, it even includes outtakes from "C.C. Ryder" with Louis Armstrong, that very infinitely famous performance. Doug Bensen of suburban Maryland who grew up not very far from me has taken those records, he borrowed copies from me, I think he may have even borrowed copies from Europe, but he was able to get his hands on every surviving Ma Rainey record he could, including the outtakes — there are a number of them — that he could. And he has done sound restoration according to current possibilities, current technology, and inevitably current tastes and everything. I think he's done a glorious job because we don't hear the record noise, whatever has been substituted to give the music a feeling of dimensionality, the feeling as though you're hearing not just an old record but that you're hearing a real performance, you know, in a real space and of course in real time. And it brings those records to life in a way that just sounds absolutely glorious to me now. But I know that in another fifty years there's going to be techniques that will supersede these and will make the versions that I think are so glorious now sound primitive by comparison. Or at least the way it makes the restorations of people, of Ma Rainey's records that they were doing in the 1940s sound pretty old you know, and it just sounds like music recorded through a wooden horn, coming through a wooden horn. And I think now we have the potential to do much better than that. What we don't always have is the taste to do it right. So that's a very subjective matter.

MR: Oh yes.

DS: A long answer to a short question.

MR: No that's — I was hoping to get something like that. And then, what — are there plans to either market or share this Ma Rainey music, and what medium will it be shared? Are they going to make CDs?

DS: Well CDs is the only way to publish something these days short of the internet so of course. It'll be on five CDs and the last one will be about two-thirds filled up. And I'm keeping my fingers crossed here, another little plug — there is a surviving interview with Harry Charles who is the Paramount Records producer and also a local retailer. I think he had retail shops. I'm not sure of this but I think I'm right, in Birmingham and Atlanta. Anyway there were connections in both places. And so he was involved with several of Ma Rainey's records in 1926, including the ones that she did with what was at the time the working Al Wynn band that came down and recorded "Soon This Morning" and some other titles with her and it was when Paramount first started using the Marsh early electric methods to make blues recordings and the results were pretty horrible. I mean they're worse than the acoustic records. But all of that came about then and so I've been lucky to have been a part of all of that and to hear the difference that it's really made. In the acoustic records, the early electrics, and all of that. I've forgotten part of your question, what am I ignoring here?

MR: No, I think you answered it very well. Do you notice with speeds of records if their source material — how do I say this — if they're listening to the source material and it seems to be in the cracks of a key, it's somewhere between you know E flat and E, do they tend to fix that or fuss with it so it's in a key?

DS: Fix what?

MR: Well —

DS: Are we assuming that all instruments were always tuned in key?

MR: That's a good point. That's a good point. Was the piano tuned to A440 or was it —

DS: Yeah. And even the horns you know.

MR: Yes, okay. I stand corrected.

DS: I don't know that there is a correct here, but it has to — you have to recognize that there's some inherent distortion at that level and in the sonic qualities. It can be adjusted but it can't be fixed because we don't know what the performance actually sounded like independent of the recording that we have in our hand. We're not hearing the performance, we're hearing a representation of the performance while we play an old record. And so it's the record that you've got to worry about because you can't re-create an event that happened a hundred years ago in any case.

MR: Wow. Have you ever participated —

DS: So it's ideal, the photography, the snapshot, the Brownie shot, you know, is going to represent an actual event but it isn't going to be the event.

MR: Okay. You just put this thought, a memory in my head. One time I attended a group that I was not quite ready to attend but they were looking at all these old photographs of jazz musicians trying to identify specific people. And you know it was funny because

someone would say, "That's Norris Turney." And another person, "Na man, that's not Norris Turney." So I wondered if you've ever participated —

DS: I've seen Norris Turney in living, but I don't think I could do that either.

MR: It was such a wonderful thing because some of these people had played with him or, you know, "Oh man, I was in a bar with him, that's not him." And have you ever participated in an audio version of that?

DS: Well that's what record collectors do all the time, isn't it?

MR: Okay. Trying to figure out —

DS: If they've got Kid Ory and Barney Bigard playing and Claude Hopkins for Christ's sake playing on those Ma Rainey records. Give me a break you know. That's just collectors' wish fulfillment you know.

MR: Yeah because, "Oh that's a Claude Hopkins lick," but as you already stated, these licks man are traded all over.

DS: Well a lot of jazz discography consists of well-meaning guesswork I think. But I don't think we're any better off for it. Because sometimes if you have information like that that you think is accurate then it's going to discourage you from trying to look for what might actually be the case. You know that famous recording — not famous — famous to record collectors, of George W. Thomas's "The Rocks" by a young pianist represented as Clay Custer, a 1923 recording? Do you know that record? Well it's represented as being George W. Thomas and it sounds like a high school kid who could barely read the sheet music trying to play the record and that's the performance. I guess that there are a couple of surviving records but Thomas himself, the acknowledged pianist — and those records are good, "The Rocks" the guy playing "The Rocks" were good. But the record collectors swear to God that it's Clay Custer and George W. Thomas are one and the same person. And once those rumors get started sometimes they're kind of what Tintin Books called it "the lies that will not die." You know? There are a lot of false attributions like Norris Turney I think.

MR: Oh yes, and like the way Bessie Smith passed away and so forth.

DS: Yeah. Very well meaning and understandable in the context of the time but in the long run they're not doing history much of a service.

MR: Would you ever go back and edit anything you've written and then found out through your own research, ensuing research, that I would amend that?

DS: Sure. Don't ask me for — I'd have to think about what they were but I've said things that I've been wrong about because they seemed accurate at the time. But I can't remember what they were.

MR: I want to run a couple of statements by you and just get your impression on them. You don't have to say no that's not correct or that's correct, but I've often read the phrase "Jazz is the only original American art form."

DS: Too bad about that, Riley Puckett. You know? What about the Carter family? Nope. What about the Norfolk Jubilee Quartet? What about everything else besides jazz that's pretty good.

MR: Yes. What about the blues?

DS: Well I don't consi — I never thought the blues and jazz were separatable when I was a kid and I'm still not sure that they are. I mean people go on about blues this and jazz that and those fans divided themselves into different camps, oh and then the blues people insist on dividing music between city blues and country blues. I think that's a false distinction. And I think — I mean if I had to divide American music I would divide it between north and south, not between black and white, not between country and jazz you know. But I think music from the north sounds different than music from the south and I like music with a southern accent better. That's about where I'm at.

MR: I'm forming a question here because it fascinates me, and I don't know if you can do this, but if you were at a cocktail party and someone asks you, "Well what is the blues anyway" what's the first thing that you want to say about it, if you want to try and bother?

DS: I don't know, I mean it's not a word that requires a precise definition. I mean it's not like something that would be in a scientific or mathematical appraisal. If it's art it's flexible. I mean isn't Bob Wills a pretty good blues singer? So what is he singing, country? Maybe. Western? Well is he singing the blues? I mean his favorite singer was Bessie Smith or does his being white disqualify it? I'm not saying yes or no to that but there's the question. Right? If you listen to some of Bob Wills' records, especially the pre-War ones, they're out swinging a lot of those big bands out of New York and Chicago because they've got that cowboy beat.

MR: The cowboy beat. Explain that.

DS: They danced like people did in the southwest, you know like those wonderful Bennie Moten records throughout the twenties and early thirties. Like those few location recordings that were made by the Basie band right after it came out of Kansas City into Chicago and to New York. And some of those other territory bands, I can't think of names right off the hand, but when you could hear other music from the southwest you're hearing Charlie Christian, you're hearing Bob Wills, you're hearing Milton Brown, you're hearing Doug [inaudible], you're hearing Hershel Evans. All of those people with a record like — there's a wonderful photo in a Bob Wills book of Bob and Henry Allen and Tommy Duncan and one or two other jazz people. Maybe it was Higginbotham or

somebody, all sitting around the table having drinks together in the forties. Those musicians knew each other. They didn't have those problems. The music was the music and if you heard a Bob Wills record without singing you wouldn't think it was a white band. Their version of "White Heat" really skunks the Jimmie Lunceford version.

MR: Yike. You know you and I could talk for about four days solid I think. I want to read —

DS: I think Frank Driggs would probably hit me across the head if he heard all of this, but I never had that discussion with Frank.

MR: I want to read something.

DS: When he discussed southwestern music he never brought into it the western sweet bands and I think they're a big part of that equation and I think the influence went both ways.

MR: Yeah Jay McShann and all those fellas talked about, you know their territory, and that their gigs were dances. And it sort of begs the question that comes about jazz and dance and jazz as a form of entertainment, and what happened when it stopped being so entertaining. I'm not sure we need to go there.

DS: Well it left the south and went to the north. Bop didn't really get to San Antonio and Oklahoma City, did it? It kind of left Oklahoma City with Charlie Christian.

MR: Good point.

DS: Who was not called a bopper until after the fact. But the southwestern bands were playing blues and they were playing arrangements of pop tunes that people could get out there on the floor and dance to and they did. When the audiences started sitting down instead of dancing up and standing there was a profound change in the music because sitting down was like listening to Bartok, and standing up was like dancing to Bob Wills.

MR: Well said. Drummer Ed Shaughnessy, I asked him once if he could define swing. And he said he thought he could but, this is a quote, he says, "Youngsters and even oldsters, they mix up the terms to swing and lock it exclusively into jazz music. Now I think bluegrass music swings like hell, without drums, it swings. It's infectious." Do you think bluegrass music swings like Ed does?

DS: My problem goes back further than that. When you say "swing" are you referring to a noun or a verb?

MR: That was Ed's point also that I'm referring to it, the process of — a verb.

DS: The music swings or it doesn't swing. Bluegrass can swing but swing is not its, that's not where the music starts from. It's not jazz music. It's music where basically out of the Virginia, West Virginia, Kentucky, Tennessee, that little quadrant of — a quadrant — because actually it's five states down there in that little nexus around Bristol, Virginia where Jimmy Rodgers and the Carter family kind of — they didn't define modern country music but they kind of set down some informal barriers as to what hillbilly music would sound like and wouldn't sound like, and it did not sound like jazz. It doesn't mean

that you couldn't play according to that rhythm. When jukeboxes came around in the 1930s all of a sudden you needed string basses for more than just big dance bands. You had to have string basses so the people could dance into taverns where there were only jukeboxes and they couldn't hear the beat unless the jukebox record had a bass on it. That's where the basses come from according to me.

MR: Oh I like that.

DS: And so beginning in the early 30s the western bands like the Light Crust Doughboys and Bob Wills and Milton Brown — they all had bass players. Then up in Chicago the Barn Dance on WLS — am I getting that wrong — anyway the Saturday Night Barn Dance out of Chicago — my memory's got huge holes in it — who had the Kentucky Ramblers and the leader was a bass player, Roy Acuff's hit records from the mid-30s from Knoxville with Knoxville people were the ones that had a string bass in it. And I think the presence or absence of a string bass in bluegrass has a lot to do with its jazz related qualities. But I think it kind of ends with the string bass because when you hear what the guitar and the banjo and the mandolin are playing, they're still referring back to Saturday night waltzes and mountain reels and 1-4-5 harmonies and all of the things that make great hillbilly music so precious and so different. And I think it's useful to keep that distinction except when Bill Monroe wanted to play a blues or something and then he'd get the bass up there and Bill could sing the blues right up there with Bob Wills and Brownie McGee.

MR: In the pantheon of American music bluegrass is not all that old, is it? Or, the things I've read they stated 1940. Is that debatable?

DS: Well Martin Heidegger had things to say about naming something and thereby changing its nature by assigning it a name. And so when there didn't used to be bluegrass, which is what the situation that I heard in the 40s and 50s, it got along just fine. And all of a sudden one day somebody decided to give it a name. Well as soon as you give something a name you have to define it, and as soon as you define something you begin to exclude qualities that do not fit your definition and you begin to decide well does this quality fit or does it not fit? And I think swing is sufficiently subjective to — I mean once you introduce that question I don't think you learn very much regardless of what your answer is because it wasn't something that bluegrass set out to do initially, but the longer bluegrass is interested and borrows and lends to jazz instrumentation with people like Gary Burton and what's his name, the bass player, Charlie Haden, Buell Neidlinger, that's who I'm trying to think of. Those people are willing to go back and forth and so are the younger progressives like Sonny Osborne and some of the people out there that are willing to play very jazzy licks on their instruments and do. But I think if you lose that 1-4-5 quality in bluegrass you'd be missing something terrible, whereas if you played all the jazz like that it would become very boring very fast.

MR: But the 1-4-5, I'm sometimes surprised, if you look up blues on Wikipedia or in dictionaries, encyclopedias, to me the twelve-bar blues is the most elegant music form that I know of. And sometimes it gets short-shriffed in the definition of blues.

DS: Uh yeah? I think blues also is more than that. I mean the twelve-bar blues, the call, the response and the — it's like what's his name, the thesis, the antithesis and the synthesis — who was the philosopher? Hegel. That's nice as far as it goes but there's music that's branching out of that all over the place that's just as traditional. I've discovered, here comes another plug for the Ma Rainey record. One of my little discoveries was the tune that Ma sings with the "Titanic Man Blues" and it goes [hums] and so on. That tune starts out as "I've Got the Blues for Home Sweet Home" in 1916 is a published popular song. I had to go to a lot of work to get all of this, and Ma sang it a second time — it's also her closing chorus to "Slow Driving Moon" but if you keep going it is also "Don't Jive Me" by Louis Armstrong, "Rent Party Blues" which Johnny Hodges sold to Duke Ellington, and what am I leaving out here — there's something else that's important — oh and it's a song that Ma knew in 1916 when she was on the big Alexander Tolliver circus touring the south with who? "Butterbeans and Susie." Do you know that "Butterbeans and Susie" record from 1960? The one that they did with the all-star band, it's a great record. I think Lars has re-issued it. But she sings, "I've got the blues for home sweet home" again, which of course must have been shared at some level with Ma Rainey in 1916. Susie's recording of it in 1960 is delightful, Topsy Chapman the New Orleans singer who died last year that Lars recorded, she sang the original Susie version that she learned from the 1960 record that Susie remembered from 1916. That's part of the Ma Rainey fabric. So where does the blues start and where does the blues end? You got me.

MR: That's a useful phrase in research, "You've got me."

DS: I don't need to know, really.

MR: Yes. Do you have to delve into the confusing world of copyrights and ownership and licensing when you get involved in re-issues?

DS: I'm not really that involved in re-issues, but it's kind of an impediment to study in a way because composer credits on record labels and often times on sheet music aren't going to tell you what you want to know which is who actually wrote the song. Those credits are going to tell you how the money is being divided up when the publisher's royalties come through. So people lean on those composer credits very heavily, like the people, well like Angela Davis and Sandra Lieb, who wrote those Ma Rainey books, they take it for granted that Ma Rainey wrote all of those songs because her names are on the music. Ma Rainey was — I'm sure she could write and improvise and exchange — she was certainly creative at many levels, but to sit down and write something that was going to be published as sheet music that had a complete arrangement on a record, I don't think they

went in that direction. I mean those are distinctions we create because music composition has become a business instead of an art. And when there's a business there's money being made, and when there's money being made you've got to decide how to divide it up and that's really what those things are good for. So yes, I think composer credits are very important. I discovered fairly early on that if I looked at those on records that I didn't know often times it would tell me — on jazz records especially — it would tell me who was playing on the jazz records. You know? And that's not always right but it's right often enough to be worthy of consideration when you see things like that there. Bessie Smith is credited with two compositions of writing, of co-writing two of Ma Rainey's compositions from one source. I have another source that says she did four of them but they were all on that one 1926 session. Clearly something went on between interests involving Bessie Smith and Ma Rainey but did they sit down and write a song together? Something tells me that didn't happen. But what did happen? I don't know.

MR: Yeah. Well look at Irving Mills and Duke Ellington. People got their fingers into the money pie throughout the music history.

DS: At least there the personalities of the historical figures are well enough known that you can pretty well guess as to what's going on. And certainly there has always been a bunch of collaboration between colleagues. Somebody'll say well he'd fix that up if he'd done thus and so in measure 32, you know that kind of thing happened. Does that entitle you to a composer credit? In some cases it does, but it's kind of up to the decisions that people make at the time. When Johnny Hodges introduced "Rent Party Blues" or his version of "I've Got the Blues for Home Sweet Home" to Duke Ellington, Duke liked the tune but in order to record it he wanted half the royalties. And that seemed fair enough because Johnny Hodges wasn't going to make any money on it if the tune didn't get recorded. It also became a primary vehicle for his soprano sax playing which he always enjoyed doing, and that's — if you're thinking of him playing soprano saxophone that's one of the tunes you think of.

MR: That's true. Didn't he —

DS: That one, whatever that flower is, you know, Precious Flower — I can't think of the title. But he did a couple of soprano sax specialty before he put the instrument away but "Rent Party Blues" is one of them.

MR: Speaking of money to be made, jazz education has become a thriving business in academia and I'm wondering if the same focus will ever be put on bluegrass and blues music? In other words could you go to a university and get a Ph.D. in bluegrass?

DS: If enough people are willing to pay money to attend those classes you betcha. Yeah. It doesn't mean that it's something you need to attend an institution of higher learning in order to get — I think it's kind of the long way around but it certainly, it's study, it's

publication, it's thought, it's everything that — it's got a value, but it's not the way that people originally learned that music. You know it happened without the aid of authorities.

MR: It happened without the aid of authorities. You've given me some good quotes here today.

DS: Well you're working for a college. I don't know how helpful anything I'm saying here is for the institution but, you know, there it is. And it's certainly true of hillbilly music too. That hasn't happened. Why doesn't Juilliard give courses in playing steel guitar? It's a very sophisticated complicated instrument that's constantly being worked on and revised with new techniques that players have and by, you know, new inventions and everything on the instrument. How come that's not in an institution of higher learning? Do we necessarily want it to be in an institution of higher learning? All of those are interesting questions.

MR: Interesting is right. When Phil Woods went to Juilliard he could not major in saxophone. He had to major in clarinet.

DS: Is that right? I didn't know that.

MR: Yeah. And it was a process. When I was in school there was no jazz, organized jazz faculty. It was a bit of a student effort. But it's interesting because sometimes when young people take it upon themselves to not only study but to perform it, it means more. You're highly invested in it.

DS: Well I think if enough people are willing to take courses in ditch digging that the college or the university would create a department because it would attract people. It's, I mean any field of knowledge is subjective as to who wants to know and who wants to teach it and what class of society it belongs to. I mean a lot of this goes back to our basic assumptions about race and class and other things too. The pedal steel guitar isn't taught at Juilliard because it isn't Mozart. I think it's about as simple as that on one level but on another level the differences are very complex.

MR: Here's an interesting quote from, you look up "bluegrass" on Wikipedia and it says, "Notes are anticipated in contrast to laid back blues where notes are behind the beat. This gives higher energy characteristics to bluegrass music.

DS: Mmm. Lot of interesting assumptions there.

MR: Yes indeed.

DS: I wouldn't argue with it but I would just say to the person well what about —

MR: It's — I just think it's interesting that people come to folks like yourself looking for specific answers but you recognize that specific answers are problematic. Is that a fair statement?

DS: Well it's a problematic statement because that's true in some instances but in other instances if you're referring to matters of fact — did this or did this not occur, and did it occur in the way that it is said to have occurred. I guess one famous instance being back to my main topic here did the movie "Ma Rainey's Black Bottom" that whole story is fictionalized and it is fictionalized in a way that almost eliminates Ma Rainey as the center of attention in the original play and of course in the movie. And the whole story that it creates is presented as like, I mean no one argues with it as factual representation but in fact the villain of the movie has to be white in order to be the villain and so they take a black person, who was the actual supervisor of recording, Mayo Williams, very famous in the recording industry when it comes to documenting black music on records for over a quarter century. And they make the Mayo Williams character white. Well what interests are being served here? Because they are being served. Where do the conflicts arise? Well that's interesting too. And so the more you try to interpret things the more you change facts because it fits your political or ideological schematic more precisely. The more you kind of are mixing up chili peppers with vanilla ice cream, the result is problematic, and that's the polite word for it.

MR: I feel like I've been duped.

DS: Well as long as you remain suspicious you're probably okay.

MR: Remain suspicious.

DS: The thing's not entirely wrong either but when people who know more than you do are telling you things that they know aren't precisely the way they're telling you then they're doing you a favor on one hand but they're doing you a disservice on another. And it's up to you to learn, you know, which are the facts and which are the accurate observations and which ones maybe aren't.

MR: Yeah I remember thinking the movie about Buddy Bolden that came out a couple of years ago was so highly fictionalized, and I assume it was because there's very little information about him. And to make a whole movie about him, it has to be highly fictionalized I guess.

DS: Well that's the new version of "Young Man With a Horn" I guess, isn't it? And nobody pretended, at least at the time, nobody pretended that that was history. People made the associations with Beiderbecke and Berigan because they were obvious examples of somebody with a huge talent that blew it, in the sense of the word.

MR: There's been a few books out focused on white musicians' contributions to jazz including our friend Randy Sandke. And I'm going to take a stab at this question — do you think black authors and researchers write differently about blues and jazz than white authors and researchers do?

DS: Well I could probably say that each author writes with his own set of principles an emphases and so on, and that the division isn't necessarily racial, it's just, you know the kind of intellectual freedom we allow ourselves among historians and critics and so on. But certainly somebody years and years ago writing about jazz was assumed to be white. We didn't have black authorities starting to get involved with the music and writing about it seriously and in some depth in creating books. That didn't really start happening until the 60s. Before then our authorities were John Hammond and Martin Williams and Charles Edward Smith and so on, all of whom were good, responsible authors and tried to get it right as much as they could, but they were outsiders looking in as opposed to insiders real racially related to the people that are responsible for the origins of the music if you're talking about blues or jazz. But the nice thing about the music is that as soon as the music was created, as soon as the blues were created in the 1910s you have room for a song like "I've Got the Blues for Home Sweet Home" that turned out not to have jazz content. It was only because there wasn't any jazz yet or at least anything that we call jazz. And I forget where I was going with that, but the critics I think tried to identify themselves racially but I don't think that they're trying to make those distinctions quite so precisely. What's his name did that long book, I've got it on the shelf, that's a history of white jazz and I would object to making that distinction in the first place.

MR: You're talking about Richard Sudhalter?

DS: Without qualification. Yeah, Richard Sudhalter. Who was a good musician, a good person, and had all of the right motives but I don't think jazz has ever been racially separated ever since its inception you know? I mean Coleman Hawkins had to have listened to Paul [inaudible] and Rudy what's his name —

MR: Rudy Wiedoeft.

DS: Yeah, yeah, and those people. Because he had to have some place to take off from there, but a whole lot of white musicians, you know, you wouldn't have had a Stan Getz without a Coleman Hawkins, would you?

MR: Or a Lester Young.

DS: You wouldn't have an Earl Bostic without Coleman Hawkins. So all of that music belongs together and I'll just repeat what I said earlier that I think it's easier and even that's not easy to separate southern music or northern music with an area like rhythm & blues where things do tend to kind of overlap. But I think the north-south distinction is a more useful one that the black and white one. And that's true of the blues too because if you're talking about white blues singers, what about Jack Teagarden, what about Jimmy Rodgers, what about Elvis Presley? Those people all had a right to sing the blues I think. They were never going to be Jimmy Rushing or Bessie Smith but that doesn't mean that they weren't pretty damn good. Bob Wills, let us not forget him.

MR: Well said. This has really been fascinating, and I appreciate your time. I wonder if you were to get up now after we're done and go put on some music —

DS: Which I do have to do.

MR: Okay. What is it going to be?

DS: Doc Watson.

MR: Doc Watson.

DS: His hundredth birthday is next week. BluegrassCountry.org, which anyone can listen to at any time over the Internet, big plug here, is going to be having a fundraiser for that entire weekend. We're going to be celebrating Doc's birthday and I've done the first hour of the broadcast and when you and I are done I've got to do the second hour of the broadcast, and one of the songs I'm going to play by Doc Watson is [sings] Do you know John Hurt/Did you shake his hand. Well I hope to emphasize that time because Hurt and Watson did know each other. They did shake hands. And Doc Watson named his son Eddie Merle because he was naming him after Eddie Arnold and Merle Travis. But what did Merle Watson do? He listened to John Hurt and he picked like that. And he was wonderful at it. Merle Watson was more like Merle Travis, who was also like John Hurt. So I think that the raciality has been mixed in almost from the inception of blues and jazz and I think without that element the music would lose an entire dimension.

MR: Wow another good quote. Thank you for your time and I wish you best —

DS: Well thank you Monk, it's been a stimulating conversation, made me think of some things that I hadn't thought of for a while, the only thing that can only occur in conversation. So I'm grateful for the opportunity to participate.

MR: Some of the oddities, I don't know why this came into my head maybe because I play the song "Rock Around the Clock" and —

DS: Oh there's another one.

MR: "Rock Around the Clock" is a swing tune.

DS: No.

MR: Well I think it is.

DS: Well it precedes swing.

MR: Okay, but I'm talking about the feel of it, which is sort of —

DS: Well the feel of it is about screwing to the clock. I mean that's what the song is about. That's what rock & roll actually means.

MR: Really? I had no idea.

DS: It's our method of reproduction. I mean the roots for that song, what was his name, J. Berni Barbour — anyway, you know "My Man Rocks Me (With One Steady Roll)." That was out there in 1921. And if the parents who objected to rhythm & blues being re-named rock & roll, if they only knew.

MR: They would have thrown those 45s out in the garbage.

DS: Yeah, really.

MR: And some they did, right?

DS: Well yeah they sure tried. And today their children and grandchildren are collecting them all over again. So I mean it's the story of the blues to start with. It was the throwaway music in the 20s and somebody is reputed to have paid in excess of 100 Gs for a Blind Willie McTell record recently. That'd give anybody the blues.

MR: It's like buying a piece of art, isn't it?

DS: Well it's certainly a hundred thousand dollars worth of music but it represents a new high in record collecting. It represents record collecting really graduating from an affordable class into something only people with incomes like Eric Clapton and Paul McCartney can afford. You know? It means more and more records are going to end up in fewer and fewer places as people like you and me lack the resources to compete with them.

MR: Well thanks again for your time and for your contributions to music and —

DS: Well thank you, Monk, I feel privileged that I was invited, thank you.

MR: All right.